A CONQUEROR AND A REFUGEE PRINCE

In 1404, an elderly European man stood uncertainly before one of the most splendid courts in the world, set within a garden outside Samarkand. He was balding, with a russet beard and fine, deep-set eyes but, even in his best robes, he would have felt drab and inadequate at the high entrance to the garden he stood before, decorated in blue and gold glazed tiles, behind which soldiers on six elephants were waiting to receive him. When Ruy González de Clavio, ambassador of Henry III of Castile, was conducted by soldiers into the presence of the monarch, he saw before him an old man sitting cross-legged on silk carpets, a beautiful palace behind him. The monarch was dressed in silk robes and wore a high white hat surmounted by a gleaming ruby and studded with pearls and precious stones. In front of him was a sparkling fountain and red apples floated on its crystal waters. The monarch's face was deeply lined, the skin lying in folds like an empty leather water gourd, and his narrow eyes were almost sightless beneath exaggeratedly arched eyebrows. But his voice was strong as he greeted Ruy González and the other kneeling ambassadors and enquired about 'his son, the king of Spain', for this monarch was Timur Beg, or Timur-i-Lang,* the great Central Asian warlord who had conquered most of the Eastern Muslim world to create the largest empire in the world at the time.

Ruy González would return to Europe where he would write at length about his journey to Timur's court. He would write of gargantuan feasts, of roasted horse and sheep meat, carved and served with corn bread, of various dressed meats, and meatballs accompanied by rice, of melons, grapes, and nectarines, and a cooling drink made of cream and sugar. He described garden pavilions and tents called dilkusha, glorious in their rich, silken cloths and fluttering tassels, set amid the fragrant shade of fruit trees. He wrote of feasts held every day by the monarch or noblemen in tented camps by the river during which the royal women were present too, eating and drinking with the men. Wine was served in addition to cream and sugar, 'for they do not consider that there is either pleasure or festivity without being drunk' and the most drunk amongst them all was celebrated by being hailed 'Bahadur', a 'valorous man'. Alongside the daily festivities, the affairs of